

Jeremiah 34 - 36

Key Notes, Cross-References, and Messianic Connections (WEB)

Tonight three chapters about obedience - one nation that broke its word, one family that kept theirs for two hundred years, and one king who took a knife to the word of God.

Slaves set free in a panic and dragged back the moment the pressure lifted.

A clan of nomads who would not drink the wine set in front of them, in the temple, on the prophet's own invitation.

A scroll read three times in one day, and burned three or four columns at a time by a king who would not even tear his robe.

Jeremiah 34 catches Judah performing righteousness under siege and reversing it when the army withdrew - and answers with the most terrible pun in the book: you would not proclaim liberty, so I proclaim a liberty to you.

Jeremiah 35 sets a family of teetotal tent-dwellers in front of Jerusalem and lets their two centuries of obedience to a dead ancestor preach the sermon.

Jeremiah 36 tells how this book nearly did not survive, and why it did.

This is not just history.

This is a mirror.

And tonight, we let the Word fill us.

CHAPTER 34 - Liberty Proclaimed and Withdrawn

Key Notes

- The siege is at full strength - Nebuchadnezzar with all his army and every kingdom under his dominion - and Jeremiah is sent to say the city will burn (Jeremiah 34:1-2).
- Zedekiah is told he will see the king of Babylon eye to eye and speak with him mouth to mouth, which is exactly what happened at Riblah before his eyes were put out (Jeremiah 34:3).
- Even here there is a mercy clause: he will not die by the sword, but in peace, with the customary burning of spices and a lament. Judgment is calibrated, not indiscriminate (Jeremiah 34:4-5).
- The military detail in verse 7 is precise - Lachish and Azekah alone still standing - and the Lachish ostraca unearthed in the 1930s mention watching for Azekah's signal fires (Jeremiah 34:7).
- Under pressure, Zedekiah leads a genuine covenant renewal: every Hebrew slave set free, sworn in the temple, with all the princes and all the people participating (Jeremiah 34:8-10).
- Then the Babylonians withdraw to meet an Egyptian force, and the freed slaves are rounded up and put back to work. Repentance that lasts exactly as long as the emergency (Jeremiah 34:11).
- Yahweh's response goes straight to the Torah: the seven-year release was commanded at the exodus, and their fathers ignored it too (Jeremiah 34:13-14).
- He credits them honestly for the moment they got it right - "you had now turned, and had done that which is right in my eyes" - before naming what they did next (Jeremiah 34:15).
- The charge is profaning the Name. The oath was sworn in the house called by His name, so breaking it dragged His reputation into their reversal (Jeremiah 34:16).
- Then the sentence, built on a bitter wordplay: you did not proclaim liberty to your brothers, so "I proclaim to you a liberty... to the sword, to the pestilence, and to the famine" (Jeremiah 34:17).
- The covenant they broke had been ratified by cutting a calf in two and walking between the halves - a self-curse, saying may this happen to me if I break it (Jeremiah 34:18-20).
- The chapter ends with the Babylonians ordered back. The reprieve that made them confident is revoked, and the city they thought was saved is burned (Jeremiah 34:21-22).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
Burial Honors Granted and Denied	Jeremiah 34:5 • 2 Chronicles 16:14 • Jeremiah 22:18-19
The Seven-Year Release	Jeremiah 34:9 • Exodus 21:2 • Deuteronomy 15:12-15
Proclaim Liberty Throughout the Land	Jeremiah 34:14 • Leviticus 25:10 • Deuteronomy 15:1-2
An Oath Sworn in His House	Jeremiah 34:15 • Jeremiah 7:10-11 • Malachi 2:10
Profaning the Name	Jeremiah 34:16 • Leviticus 19:12 • Ezekiel 20:39
A Liberty to Sword and Famine	Jeremiah 34:17 • Leviticus 26:25 • Deuteronomy 28:25

Topic	References
Cutting the Calf in Two	Jeremiah 34:18 • Genesis 15:9-18 • Exodus 24:8
The Egyptian Reprieve	Jeremiah 34:21 • Jeremiah 37:5-11 • Ezekiel 17:15

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
Liberty Proclaimed to the Captives	Jeremiah 34:9 • Luke 4:18-19 • Isaiah 61:1
Judged by the Measure We Use	Jeremiah 34:17 • Matthew 7:2 • James 2:13
A Covenant Made Binding by Death	Jeremiah 34:18 • Hebrews 9:16-17 • Colossians 2:14
The One Who Walked Between the Pieces	Jeremiah 34:18 • Genesis 15:17 • Galatians 3:13
No Longer Slaves but Free	Jeremiah 34:11 • Galatians 5:1 • John 8:36
Repentance That Outlasts the Emergency	Jeremiah 34:15-16 • 2 Corinthians 7:10 • Matthew 13:20-21

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 34 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - the slave release, its reversal, and the covenant-cutting ceremony behind verse 18
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 34](#) - the Torah release statutes of Exodus 21, Leviticus 25, and Deuteronomy 15 in their covenant setting
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 34](#) - exposition of the liberty wordplay and what it reveals about pressure-driven repentance

Jeremiah 34 - Opening Intro

This chapter is about a good decision that did not survive contact with better circumstances.

The Babylonians are at the wall. Zedekiah calls the nation together and does something Judah had not done in living memory: he obeys the release law. Every Hebrew slave freed. Sworn in the temple. Princes and people all in. If the chapter ended at verse 10 it would be one of the brightest moments in the book.

Then Egypt marches out, Babylon lifts the siege to deal with them, and the pressure comes off. And within what appears to be days, the same men go and take their servants back.

It is worth being honest about what that exposes, because it is not primarily a story about slavery. It is a story about what our obedience is actually anchored to. Theirs was anchored to fear, and fear is a real motivator with a short shelf life. When the thing they were afraid of moved away, so did the obedience.

Yahweh's answer is the sharpest wordplay in Jeremiah. The word is *deror* - liberty, release, the term from the Jubilee legislation. You would not proclaim *deror* to your brothers, He says, so I hereby proclaim *deror* to you: to the sword, to the pestilence, and to the famine. You want to keep people in bondage; fine, I will release something else instead.

And verse 18 reaches back to Genesis 15. To cut a covenant in the ancient Near East, you cut an animal in half and walked between the pieces, saying in effect: may I be made like this animal if I break my word. Judah did that in the temple, and then broke it inside a month. The chapter says their bodies will lie like the calf's.

Before we read, ask the uncomfortable question this chapter is designed to raise. What have we promised God under pressure, and quietly taken back once the pressure lifted?

Jeremiah 34:1-22 (WEB)

1 The word which came to Jeremiah from Yahweh, when Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon, with all his army, all the kingdoms of the earth that were under his dominion, and all the peoples, were fighting against Jerusalem and against all its cities, saying:

2 "Yahweh, the God of Israel, says, 'Go, and speak to Zedekiah king of Judah, and tell him, Yahweh says, "Behold, I will give this city into the hand of the king of Babylon and he will burn it with fire.

3 You won't escape out of his hand, but will surely be taken and delivered into his hand. Your eyes will see the eyes of the king of Babylon, and he will speak with you mouth to mouth. You will go to Babylon.'"

4 "Yet hear Yahweh's word, O Zedekiah king of Judah: Yahweh says concerning you, 'You won't die by the sword.

5 You will die in peace; and with the burnings of your fathers, the former kings who were before you, so they will make a burning for you. They will lament you, saying, "Ah Lord!" for I have spoken the word,' says Yahweh."¹

6 Then Jeremiah the prophet spoke all these words to Zedekiah king of Judah in Jerusalem,

7 when the king of Babylon's army was fighting against Jerusalem, and against all the cities of Judah that were left, against Lachish and against Azekah; for these alone remained of the cities of Judah as fortified cities.

8 The word came to Jeremiah from Yahweh, after king Zedekiah had made a covenant with all the people who were at Jerusalem, to proclaim liberty to them;

¹ Cross-Reference: [2 Chronicles 16:14](#) • [Jeremiah 22:18-19](#) - the burning of spices as a royal honor, and the king who was denied any lament at all

9 that every man should let his male servant, and every man his female servant, who is a Hebrew or a Hebrewess, go free; that no one should make bondservants of them, of a Jew his brother.^{2,3}

10 All the princes and all the people obeyed who had entered into the covenant, that everyone should let his male servant, and everyone his female servant go free, that no one should make bondservants of them any more. They obeyed and let them go;

11 but afterwards they turned, and caused the servants and the handmaids, whom they had let go free, to return, and brought them into subjection for servants and for handmaids.

12 Therefore Yahweh's word came to Jeremiah from Yahweh, saying,

13 "Yahweh, the God of Israel, says: 'I made a covenant with your fathers in the day that I brought them out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of bondage, saying,

14 At the end of seven years, every man of you shall release his brother who is a Hebrew, who has been sold to you, and has served you six years. You shall let him go free from you; but your fathers didn't listen to me, and didn't incline their ear.'⁴

15 You had now turned, and had done that which is right in my eyes, in every man proclaiming liberty to his neighbor. You had made a covenant before me in the house which is called by my name;⁵

16 but you turned and profaned my name, and every man caused his servant, and every man his handmaid, whom you had let go free at their pleasure, to return. You brought them into subjection, to be to you for servants and for handmaids."⁶

17 Therefore Yahweh says: "You have not listened to me, to proclaim liberty, every man to his brother, and every man to his neighbor. Behold, I proclaim to you a liberty," says Yahweh, "to the sword, to the pestilence, and to the famine. I will make you be tossed back and forth among all the kingdoms of the earth."^{7,8}

² **Cross-Reference:** [Exodus 21:2](#) • [Deuteronomy 15:12-15](#) - the Hebrew servant released in the seventh year, and not sent away empty-handed

³ **Messianic Connection:** [Luke 4:18-19](#) • [Isaiah 61:1](#) - the Jubilee text read at Nazareth - liberty proclaimed to captives and the oppressed set free

⁴ **Cross-Reference:** [Leviticus 25:10](#) • [Deuteronomy 15:1-2](#) - proclaim liberty throughout the land to all its inhabitants - the year of release

⁵ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 7:10-11](#) • [Malachi 2:10](#) - the house called by His name treated as cover, and covenant broken brother against brother

⁶ **Cross-Reference:** [Leviticus 19:12](#) • [Ezekiel 20:39](#) - swearing falsely by His name and so profaning it - the specific charge here

⁷ **Cross-Reference:** [Leviticus 26:25](#) • [Deuteronomy 28:25](#) - the sword avenging the covenant, and defeat before enemies as its named consequence

⁸ **Messianic Connection:** [Matthew 7:2](#) • [James 2:13](#) - measured back with the measure we use, and judgment without mercy to one who showed none

18 I will give the men who have transgressed my covenant, who have not performed the words of the covenant which they made before me, when they cut the calf in two and passed between its parts.^{9,10}

19 the princes of Judah, the princes of Jerusalem, the eunuchs, the priests, and all the people of the land, who passed between the parts of the calf;

20 I will even give them into the hand of their enemies, and into the hand of those who seek their life. Their dead bodies will be food for the birds of the sky and for the animals of the earth.

21 "I will give Zedekiah king of Judah and his princes into the hands of their enemies, into the hands of those who seek their life and into the hands of the king of Babylon's army, who has gone away from you."¹¹

22 Behold, I will command," says Yahweh, "and cause them to return to this city. They will fight against it, take it, and burn it with fire. I will make the cities of Judah a desolation, without inhabitant."¹²

⁹ **Cross-Reference:** [Genesis 15:9-18](#) • [Exodus 24:8](#) - the covenant cut between the pieces, and the blood of the covenant sprinkled on the people

¹⁰ **Messianic Connection:** [Hebrews 9:16-17](#) • [Colossians 2:14](#) - a covenant in force only where there has been a death, and the record of debt nailed to the cross

¹¹ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 37:5-11](#) • [Ezekiel 17:15](#) - Pharaoh's army drawing Babylon away, and the rebellion that leaned on Egypt for help

¹² **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 32:29](#) • [2 Kings 25:9](#) - the city set on fire, exactly as announced, when the Chaldeans returned

CHAPTER 35 - The Rechabites and the Sermon That Needed No Words

Key Notes

- The chapter jumps backward to Jehoiakim's reign, placed here for its argument rather than its date - a deliberate contrast with the covenant-breakers of chapter 34 (Jeremiah 35:1).
- The instruction is peculiar: bring a whole clan into a temple chamber and offer them wine. Jeremiah is told to stage a temptation (Jeremiah 35:2).
- The Rechabites are not Israelites by descent but Kenites, attached to Judah - which sharpens the comparison considerably (Jeremiah 35:3).
- The setting is public and official. Bowls of wine, cups, a room beside the princes' chamber, and the prophet himself saying "Drink wine!" (Jeremiah 35:5).
- Their answer is immediate and total: "We will drink no wine." No hesitation, no negotiation, no asking whether this occasion might be an exception (Jeremiah 35:6).
- The command they cite is two hundred years old, given by Jonadab son of Rechab, who rode with Jehu in the ninth century. The man has been dead for eight generations (Jeremiah 35:6).
- The terms are severe - no wine, no houses, no seed, no vineyards, tents only - and they have kept every clause, including their wives, sons, and daughters (Jeremiah 35:8-10).
- They are honest about the one adjustment they made: they came inside the walls because of the Chaldean army. Faithfulness is not the same as rigidity (Jeremiah 35:11).
- Yahweh draws the comparison Himself and it is devastating. Jonadab spoke once and was obeyed for two centuries; "I have spoken to you, rising up early and speaking, and you have not listened" (Jeremiah 35:14).
- The contrast is not about wine at all. It is about the weight a word carries with the people who receive it, measured against the standing of the one who spoke it (Jeremiah 35:15-16).
- The verdict on Judah is stated in the plainest terms in the book: "I have spoken to them, but they have not heard; and I have called to them, but they have not answered" (Jeremiah 35:17).
- The Rechabites receive a blessing framed in priestly language - Jonadab will never lack a man to stand before Yahweh - given to outsiders for ordinary obedience (Jeremiah 35:18-19).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
Jonadab Son of Rechab	Jeremiah 35:2 • 2 Kings 10:15-16 • 1 Chronicles 2:55
Pressed to Drink and Refusing	Jeremiah 35:5 • Amos 2:12 • Daniel 1:8
Vows of Abstinence in Israel	Jeremiah 35:6 • Numbers 6:2-4 • Judges 13:4-5
Sheltering When the Invader Comes	Jeremiah 35:11 • Jeremiah 4:5-6 • Isaiah 26:20
Instruction Offered and Refused	Jeremiah 35:13 • Proverbs 1:23-25 • Isaiah 28:12

Topic	References
Rising Up Early and Speaking	Jeremiah 35:14 • Jeremiah 7:13 • Jeremiah 25:3
The Standing Call to Return	Jeremiah 35:15 • Jeremiah 18:11 • 2 Kings 17:13
“I Called, and You Did Not Answer”	Jeremiah 35:17 • Proverbs 1:24-28 • Zechariah 7:13

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
Dwelling in Tents, Looking for a City	Jeremiah 35:7 • Hebrews 11:9-10 • 2 Corinthians 5:1
Tradition Kept While God’s Word Is Broken	Jeremiah 35:16 • Matthew 15:3-6 • Matthew 21:28-31
Outsiders Who Obeyed	Jeremiah 35:19 • Matthew 8:10 • Romans 9:30-31
Never Lacking a Man to Stand Before Him	Jeremiah 35:19 • 1 Samuel 2:35 • Jeremiah 33:17-18
Serving Him Day and Night	Jeremiah 35:19 • Revelation 7:15 • Matthew 5:19
Obedience Learned in a Household	Jeremiah 35:8 • Ephesians 6:1-4 • 2 Timothy 1:5

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 35 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - the Rechabite object lesson and its use as a contrast with Judah’s disobedience
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 35](#) - the Rechabites’ vow read alongside Torah obedience rather than as asceticism for its own sake
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 35](#) - exposition of why the comparison indicts the hearer rather than commending the vow

Jeremiah 35 - Opening Intro

Yahweh sets up a test, and it is not the Rechabites who are being tested.

Here is the scene. Jeremiah brings an entire extended family - men, sons, brothers - into a chamber of the temple. He sets out bowls of wine and cups. And then the prophet of Yahweh, standing in the house of Yahweh, says to them: drink.

Every social pressure in that room points one direction. The venue is sacred. The man offering is a prophet. Refusing looks like impiety.

They refuse without a pause. “We will drink no wine.” And the reason they give is that a man named Jonadab told them not to - a man who rode in Jehu’s chariot two hundred years earlier and has been dead for eight generations.

Two things are worth noticing before the comparison lands. First, the Rechabites are not Israelites. Chronicles ties them to the Kenites, Jethro’s people. They are outsiders who attached themselves to Judah. Second, they are not rigid fanatics - verse 11 has them admitting they broke the tent rule and moved into the city because there was an army in the countryside. They understood the difference between the principle and the letter.

Then Yahweh makes His point, and it lands like a hammer. Jonadab spoke once, and his descendants obeyed for two centuries. Yahweh has spoken continuously, rising up early, sending prophet after prophet - and Judah has not listened once.

The chapter is careful not to praise the vow itself. Yahweh never commands anyone to stop drinking wine or building houses. What He praises is that a word was received as binding by people who honored the one who spoke it.

Before we read, sit with that quietly. The measure of what we obey is the measure of who we think is speaking. Judah kept plenty of customs. They just did not keep His.

Jeremiah 35:1-19 (WEB)

1 The word which came to Jeremiah from Yahweh in the days of Jehoiakim the son of Josiah, king of Judah, saying,

2 “Go to the house of the Rechabites, and speak to them, and bring them into Yahweh’s house, into one of the rooms, and give them wine to drink.”¹³

3 Then I took Jaazaniah the son of Jeremiah, the son of Habazziniah, with his brothers, all his sons, and the whole house of the Rechabites;

4 and I brought them into Yahweh’s house, into the room of the sons of Hanan the son of Igdaiah, the man of God, which was by the room of the princes, which was above the room of Maaseiah the son of Shallum, the keeper of the threshold.

5 I set before the sons of the house of the Rechabites bowls full of wine, and cups; and I said to them, “Drink wine!”¹⁴

6 But they said, “We will drink no wine; for Jonadab the son of Rechab, our father, commanded us, saying, ‘You shall drink no wine, neither you, nor your sons, forever.’”¹⁵

¹³ Cross-Reference: [2 Kings 10:15-16](#) • [1 Chronicles 2:55](#) - Jonadab riding with Jehu against Baal, and the Rechabites reckoned among the Kenites

¹⁴ Cross-Reference: [Amos 2:12](#) • [Daniel 1:8](#) - Nazirites pressed to drink wine, and a young man purposing not to defile himself

7 You shall not build a house, sow seed, plant a vineyard, or have any; but all your days you shall dwell in tents, that you may live many days in the land in which you live as nomads.¹⁶

8 We have obeyed the voice of Jonadab the son of Rechab, our father, in all that he commanded us, to drink no wine all our days, we, our wives, our sons, or our daughters;

9 and not to build houses for ourselves to dwell in. We have no vineyard, field, or seed;

10 but we have lived in tents, and have obeyed, and done according to all that Jonadab our father commanded us.

11 But when Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon came up into the land, we said, 'Come, and let us go to Jerusalem for fear of the army of the Chaldeans, and for fear of the army of the Syrians; so we will dwell at Jerusalem.'¹⁷

12 Then Yahweh's word came to Jeremiah, saying,

13 "Yahweh of Armies, the God of Israel, says: 'Go and tell the men of Judah and the inhabitants of Jerusalem, "Will you not receive instruction to listen to my words?" says Yahweh.¹⁸

14 "The words of Jonadab the son of Rechab that he commanded his sons, not to drink wine, are performed; and to this day they drink none, for they obey their father's commandment; but I have spoken to you, rising up early and speaking, and you have not listened to me.¹⁹

15 I have sent also to you all my servants the prophets, rising up early and sending them, saying, 'Every one of you must return now from his evil way, amend your doings, and don't go after other gods to serve them, then you will dwell in the land which I have given to you and to your fathers:' but you have not inclined your ear, nor listened to me.²⁰

16 The sons of Jonadab the son of Rechab have performed the commandment of their father which he commanded them, but this people has not listened to me."²¹

¹⁵ **Cross-Reference:** [Numbers 6:2-4](#) • [Judges 13:4-5](#) - the Nazirite vow and Samson's mother - abstinence as a sign of consecration in Israel

¹⁶ **Messianic Connection:** [Hebrews 11:9-10](#) • [2 Corinthians 5:1](#) - dwelling in tents while waiting for a city with foundations, whose builder is God

¹⁷ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 4:5-6](#) • [Isaiah 26:20](#) - the call to gather into the fortified cities and hide until the indignation passes

¹⁸ **Cross-Reference:** [Proverbs 1:23-25](#) • [Isaiah 28:12](#) - reproof offered and refused, and a promised rest they would not hear

¹⁹ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 7:13](#) • [Jeremiah 25:3](#) - the refrain of the whole book - He spoke early and often, and they did not listen

²⁰ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 18:11](#) • [2 Kings 17:13](#) - the same call sent to Israel and Judah by every prophet and every seer

²¹ **Messianic Connection:** [Matthew 15:3-6](#) • [Matthew 21:28-31](#) - human tradition kept scrupulously while God's command is set aside, and the son who actually went

17 “Therefore Yahweh, the God of Armies, the God of Israel, says: ‘Behold, I will bring on Judah and on all the inhabitants of Jerusalem all the evil that I have pronounced against them; because I have spoken to them, but they have not heard; and I have called to them, but they have not answered.’”²²

18 Jeremiah said to the house of the Rechabites, “Yahweh of Armies, the God of Israel, says: ‘Because you have obeyed the commandment of Jonadab your father, and kept all his precepts, and done according to all that he commanded you;’

19 therefore Yahweh of Armies, the God of Israel, says: ‘Jonadab the son of Rechab will not lack a man to stand before me forever.’”^{23,24}

²² Cross-Reference: [Proverbs 1:24-28](#) • [Zechariah 7:13](#) - I called and you refused - so when they called, He would not hear

²³ Cross-Reference: [1 Samuel 2:35](#) • [Jeremiah 33:17-18](#) - a faithful house raised up, never lacking a man to stand before Him

²⁴ Messianic Connection: [Revelation 7:15](#) • [Matthew 5:19](#) - those who serve Him day and night in His temple, and whoever does and teaches His commands

CHAPTER 36 - The Scroll, the Penknife, and the Fire

Key Notes

- The year is Jehoiakim's fourth - the same year as chapter 25, the year Nebuchadnezzar came to power. Twenty-three years of preaching are about to be committed to writing (Jeremiah 36:1).
- The command is to collect everything: all the words spoken against Israel, Judah, and the nations, from the days of Josiah to that day (Jeremiah 36:2).
- The stated purpose is not archival but pastoral - "it may be that the house of Judah will hear... that I may forgive their iniquity and their sin" (Jeremiah 36:3).
- Baruch son of Neriah appears as the scribe, taking dictation. Without him this book would not exist in the form we have it (Jeremiah 36:4).
- Jeremiah is barred from the temple, so the reading is delegated. The word gets in where the prophet cannot (Jeremiah 36:5-8).
- A national fast provides the occasion, and Baruch reads the scroll publicly from the chamber of Gemariah son of Shaphan - the same reform-minded family that shielded Jeremiah before (Jeremiah 36:9-10).
- The scroll is read three times in one day: to the people, then to the princes, then to the king. Each audience responds differently to identical words (Jeremiah 36:11-21).
- The princes are genuinely afraid, tell Baruch to hide with Jeremiah, and try to protect the scroll by leaving it in Elishama's chamber (Jeremiah 36:16-20).
- The king is in his winter house with a fire burning. As Jehudi reads, Jehoiakim cuts off each section with a scribe's penknife and feeds it into the brazier (Jeremiah 36:22-23).
- Verse 24 is the hinge, and it is written to be compared: neither the king nor his servants were afraid, and they did not tear their garments - which is precisely what Josiah his father did (Jeremiah 36:24).
- Three men do beg him not to burn it, and are ignored. There is always someone in the room who knows better (Jeremiah 36:25).
- The order goes out to arrest Baruch and Jeremiah, and the narrative adds three words that decide the chapter: "but Yahweh hid them" (Jeremiah 36:26).
- The scroll is rewritten, and the closing line is the quiet triumph of the book: "and many similar words were added to them." Burning it made it longer (Jeremiah 36:27-32).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic

Write It in a Book

"It May Be They Will Hear"

Baruch the Scribe

Topic

A Fast Proclaimed in Crisis

Trembling at His Word

Hiding the Faithful

Cutting Away the Word

A Heart Unmoved

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
The Word That Does Not Burn	Jeremiah 36:23 • Isaiah 40:8 • Matthew 24:35
Hidden by Yahweh Until the Hour	Jeremiah 36:26 • Psalm 27:5 • John 8:59
Forever Settled in Heaven	Jeremiah 36:28 • Psalm 119:89 • 1 Peter 1:24-25
All Scripture God-Breathed	Jeremiah 36:32 • 2 Timothy 3:16 • 2 Peter 1:21
Rejected by the King, Received by the Remnant	Jeremiah 36:24-25 • John 1:11-12 • Luke 7:29-30
Opposition That Enlarges the Word	Jeremiah 36:32 • Acts 8:1-4 • Philippians 1:12-14

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 36 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - the dictation to Baruch, the three readings, and Jehoiakim's burning of the scroll
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 36](#) - the transmission and preservation of the prophetic word through this episode
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 36](#) - exposition of the deliberate contrast between Jehoiakim's brazier and Josiah's torn robe

Jeremiah 36 - Opening Intro

This is the chapter that explains why you can read the other fifty-one.

For twenty-three years Jeremiah's ministry has been spoken. Now Yahweh tells him to write it all down, and the reason given in verse 3 is not preservation - it is repentance. Maybe if they hear the whole thing at once, laid out from Josiah's day to this one, they will turn, and I will forgive. The scroll is a last appeal in written form.

Then watch the same words hit three audiences on the same day.

The people hear it at the fast, and the text records no response at all. The princes hear it and turn to one another in fear - real fear, the kind that makes them warn Baruch to hide and try to get the scroll somewhere safe. And the king hears it in his winter apartment with a brazier going, and takes a knife to it.

The detail in verse 23 is worth slowing down for. Jehudi reads three or four columns; Jehoiakim cuts them off and drops them in the fire; repeat, until the whole scroll is gone. This is not a flash of temper. It is patient, methodical destruction, performed while the reading continues.

And verse 24 is written by an author who expects you to remember 2 Kings 22. When Josiah - Jehoiakim's own father - heard the recovered book of the law read aloud, he tore his clothes. The text says of the son: they were not afraid, and did not tear their garments. Same family, same throne room, opposite response to the same God.

Then the sentence that carries the whole chapter: they came to arrest Baruch and Jeremiah, "but Yahweh hid them." No angel, no miracle described. Just three words explaining why the search failed.

Before we read, hold the last line and let it be a comfort the next time it looks like the word is losing. He burned it, so Jeremiah dictated it again - and this time it was longer. You can destroy a copy. You cannot destroy what was said.

Jeremiah 36:1-32 (WEB)

1 In the fourth year of Jehoiakim the son of Josiah, king of Judah, this word came to Jeremiah from Yahweh, saying,

2 "Take a scroll of a book, and write in it all the words that I have spoken to you against Israel, and against Judah, and against all the nations, from the day I spoke to you, from the days of Josiah, even to this day."²⁵

3 It may be that the house of Judah will hear all the evil which I intend to do to them; that they may each return from his evil way; that I may forgive their iniquity and their sin."²⁶

4 Then Jeremiah called Baruch the son of Neriah; and Baruch wrote from the mouth of Jeremiah all Yahweh's words, which he had spoken to him, on a scroll of a book.²⁷

5 Jeremiah commanded Baruch, saying, "I am restricted. I can't go into Yahweh's house.

²⁵ Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 30:2](#) • [Exodus 17:14](#) - the recurring command to commit the word to writing so it outlives the moment

²⁶ Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 26:3](#) • [Ezekiel 12:3](#) - the word delivered in hope of not having to be fulfilled - it may be they will hear

²⁷ Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 45:1](#) • [Romans 16:22](#) - Baruch the scribe, who gets his own oracle later, and Tertius who wrote out Romans

6 Therefore you go, and read from the scroll which you have written from my mouth, Yahweh's words, in the ears of the people in Yahweh's house on the fast day. Also you shall read them in the ears of all Judah who come out of their cities.

7 It may be they will present their supplication before Yahweh, and will each return from his evil way; for Yahweh has pronounced great anger and wrath against this people."

8 Baruch the son of Neriah did according to all that Jeremiah the prophet commanded him, reading in the book Yahweh's words in Yahweh's house.

9 Now in the fifth year of Jehoiakim the son of Josiah, king of Judah, in the ninth month, all the people in Jerusalem, and all the people who came from the cities of Judah to Jerusalem, proclaimed a fast before Yahweh.²⁸

10 Then Baruch read the words of Jeremiah from the book in Yahweh's house, in the room of Gemariah the son of Shaphan, the scribe, in the upper court, at the entry of the new gate of Yahweh's house, in the ears of all the people.

11 When Micaiah the son of Gemariah, the son of Shaphan, had heard out of the book all Yahweh's words,

12 he went down into the king's house, into the scribe's room: and behold, all the princes were sitting there, Elishama the scribe, Delaiah the son of Shemaiah, Elnathan the son of Achbor, Gemariah the son of Shaphan, Zedekiah the son of Hananiah, and all the princes.

13 Then Micaiah declared to them all the words that he had heard, when Baruch read the book in the ears of the people.

14 Therefore all the princes sent Jehudi the son of Nethaniah, the son of Shelemiah, the son of Cushi, to Baruch, saying, "Take in your hand the scroll in which you have read in the ears of the people, and come." So Baruch the son of Neriah took the scroll in his hand, and came to them.

15 They said to him, "Sit down now, and read it in our hearing." So Baruch read it in their hearing.

16 Now when they had heard all the words, they turned in fear one toward another, and said to Baruch, "We will surely tell the king of all these words."²⁹

17 They asked Baruch, saying, "Tell us now, how did you write all these words at his mouth?"

18 Then Baruch answered them, "He dictated all these words to me with his mouth, and I wrote them with ink in the book."

19 Then the princes said to Baruch, "You and Jeremiah go hide. Don't let anyone know where you are."³⁰

²⁸ Cross-Reference: [Jonah 3:5](#) • [2 Chronicles 20:3](#) - a fast proclaimed in crisis - which in Nineveh's case actually turned the sentence

²⁹ Cross-Reference: [2 Kings 22:11](#) • [Isaiah 66:2](#) - Josiah tearing his clothes at the reading, and the one to whom Yahweh looks: he who trembles at His word

³⁰ Cross-Reference: [1 Kings 18:4](#) • [Acts 9:25](#) - Obadiah hiding a hundred prophets, and Paul let down the wall in a basket

20 They went in to the king into the court; but they had laid up the scroll in the room of Elishama the scribe. Then they told all the words in the hearing of the king.

21 So the king sent Jehudi to get the scroll; and he took it out of the room of Elishama the scribe. Jehudi read it in the hearing of the king, and in the hearing of all the princes who stood beside the king.

22 Now the king was sitting in the winter house in the ninth month; and there was a fire in the brazier burning before him.

23 When Jehudi had read three or four leaves, the king cut it with the penknife, and cast it into the fire that was in the brazier, until all the scroll was consumed in the fire that was in the brazier. ^{31,32}

24 The king and his servants who heard all these words were not afraid, and didn't tear their garments. ³³

25 Moreover Elnathan and Delaiah and Gemariah had made intercession to the king that he would not burn the scroll; but he would not listen to them.

26 The king commanded Jerahmeel the king's son, and Seraiah the son of Azriel, and Shelemiah the son of Abdeel, to arrest Baruch the scribe and Jeremiah the prophet; but Yahweh hid them. ³⁴

27 Then Yahweh's word came to Jeremiah, after the king had burned the scroll, and the words which Baruch wrote at the mouth of Jeremiah, saying,

28 "Take again another scroll, and write in it all the former words that were in the first scroll, which Jehoiakim the king of Judah has burned. ³⁵

29 Concerning Jehoiakim king of Judah you shall say, 'Yahweh says: "You have burned this scroll, saying, "Why have you written therein, saying, 'The king of Babylon will certainly come and destroy this land, and will cause to cease from there man and animal?'"'"

30 Therefore Yahweh says concerning Jehoiakim king of Judah: "He will have no one to sit on David's throne. His dead body will be cast out in the day to the heat, and in the night to the frost.

31 I will punish him, his offspring, and his servants for their iniquity. I will bring on them, on the inhabitants of Jerusalem, and on the men of Judah, all the evil that I have pronounced against them, but they didn't listen. '"'"

³¹ **Cross-Reference:** [Deuteronomy 4:2](#) • [Revelation 22:19](#) - nothing to be added or taken away - and a warning to anyone who takes away from the words

³² **Messianic Connection:** [Isaiah 40:8](#) • [Matthew 24:35](#) - the grass withers and the flower fades, but the word of our God stands forever

³³ **Cross-Reference:** [2 Kings 22:19](#) • [Proverbs 29:1](#) - the tender heart of the father, and the neck hardened so often it is broken beyond remedy

³⁴ **Cross-Reference:** [Psalm 27:5](#) • [Psalm 31:20](#) - hidden in His pavilion, kept secretly in His presence from the strife of tongues

³⁵ **Messianic Connection:** [Psalm 119:89](#) • [1 Peter 1:24-25](#) - forever settled in heaven, the living and abiding word that endures forever

32 Then took Jeremiah another scroll, and gave it to Baruch the scribe, the son of Neriah, who wrote therein from the mouth of Jeremiah all the words of the book which Jehoiakim king of Judah had burned in the fire; and many similar words were added to them.³⁶

³⁶ **Cross-Reference:** [Jeremiah 45:1-5](#) • [2 Timothy 3:16](#) - Baruch's own weariness answered by Yahweh, and all Scripture breathed out by God

Major Themes Across Jeremiah 34-36

- Repentance anchored to fear rather than to God, and how quickly it reverses when pressure lifts
- Liberty as a covenant obligation, and the terrible symmetry of a liberty proclaimed back to us
- Oaths sworn in His house that drag His name into our reversals
- Covenant as self-curse - walking between the pieces and meaning it
- A word's weight measured by the standing of the one who spoke it
- Outsiders who obeyed a dead ancestor for two centuries, against a nation that would not hear the living God
- Faithfulness distinguished from rigidity: the Rechabites moved into the city and were still commended
- The same words meeting three audiences and exposing three hearts in a single day
- Josiah's torn robe against Jehoiakim's penknife - the family resemblance that failed to carry
- Providence with no visible machinery: "but Yahweh hid them"
- A word that cannot be destroyed, and opposition that only makes it longer

Benediction

Let this be the word that goes before us tonight:

May the God who watched Judah free its slaves and take them back keep us from promises made only under pressure, and may what we vow in the hard season still stand in the easy one.

May we proclaim liberty to everyone within our reach - release what we are holding, forgive what we are owed - so that liberty is not one day proclaimed against us.

May we never treat His house as cover for what we intend to undo the moment we leave it.

May the word of God carry more weight with us than any word we have inherited from men, and may our obedience be measured by who is speaking rather than by what it costs.

May we be found among those who tremble at His word rather than among those who hear it read and feel nothing.

May He hide us when we need hiding, and give us the courage to be the ones who beg the king not to burn the scroll.

And when what we have labored over is cut up and thrown in the fire, may we take another scroll and begin again, trusting the One who adds many similar words to what men tried to destroy.

May every promise He has spoken over us stand up, come forth, and manifest in its appointed time.

Amen.